what we have, but others don't. Therefore, for outsiders, politics is a leap of faith. There is no toolkit, mentor or benefactor for those outside the status quo. We struggle to fit in and make sense of the norms that both include and exclude. Consequently, young politicos are forced to wait in the shadows for years, with no opportunities to do something purposeful or for upward mobility. This is especially problematic because such people have no safety nets, fortunes or soft cushions to fall back on.

It is critical to understand the psychological make-up of such people. Sacrificing all the trappings of a normal life, it takes tremendous fortitude to stay true to one's principles and ideology. To not lose oneself. I think all of us have at one point felt like we are looking at the world through a glass wall—there and not really there; acting in it, but not partaking of it; and seeing all, but not really in it. We don't have the luxury of a normal life, of a routine, or small perks and comforts. This complex situation can be extremely overwhelming and alienating. Like a thick layer of ash choking the fires in our bellies, it afflicts many of us in politics. And so we erect walls around ourselves to avoid any exposure or vulnerability. After all, it is comforting to be cynical and cold. But the BJY brought together all of us Karnas (to borrow from the Mahabharata). It reminded us that we were not alone, that we were united in a covenant to do and be more than our individual selves. Even though the conversations between the yatris may not have been the most stimulating, as Dr Anshul Trivedi attests in his article, the Yatra substantively broke down barriers between all of us, as well as between leaders and karyakartas (political workers). Only time will tell whether this also translates into structural reformations that create a more equitable level playing field within politics.

Thus, as Dr Kanhaiya Kumar suggests in his article, in a very real sense, the BJY brought out the worst and the best in people. As the ancient Greek philosopher Heraclitus said, 'No man ever steps in the same river twice, for it's not the same river and he's not the same man.' That is very applicable to the Yatra, which humbled and changed most of us. Many of us are different people today than we were when the Yatra started. A lot of us (including me) came with preconceived notions of our abilities, skills and importance.